

The Soul MACHINE

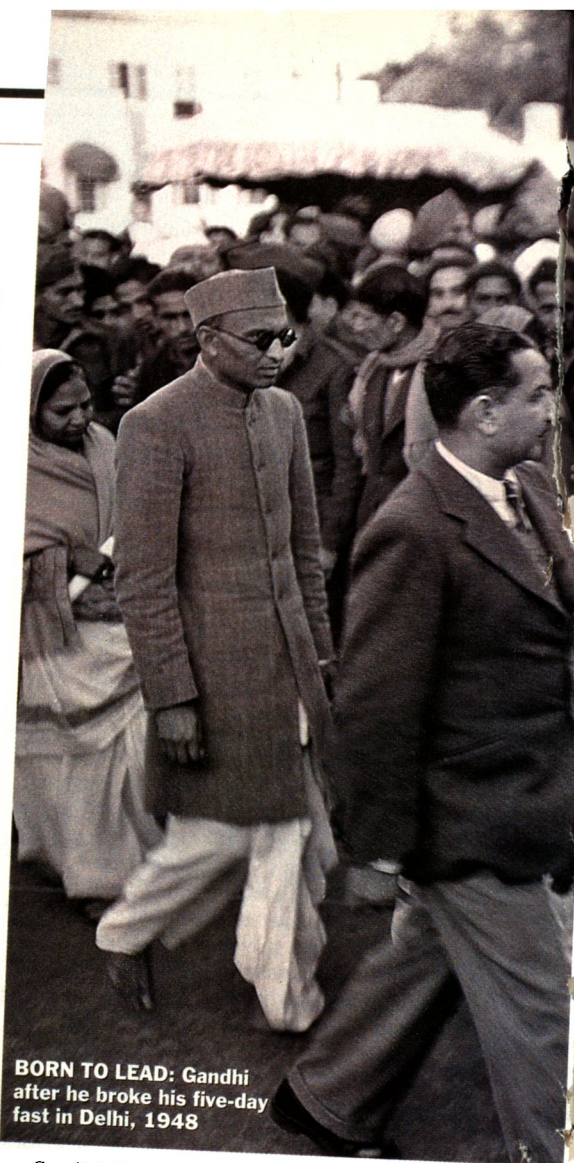
A simple act, accompanied neither by gunfire nor fanfare, became an idea that moved millions, shattered a colonial illusion, and freed a nation from years of bondage

■ By Abhijat Joshi

How many people in India know that the word satyagraha was coined not from a flight of poetic inspiration, but as the result of a newspaper advertisement? At first, Gandhiji borrowed Henry David Thoreau's phrase "passive resistance" to describe his movement against the unjust laws of segregation in South Africa in the 1890s. But he soon found the term inadequate to define the facets of the movement: commitment to non-violence, empathy for the enemy, absolute transparency, willingness to admit mistakes publicly and an attachment to the truth. In his quest for a phrase that would successfully evoke these aspects, Gandhiji made, what I know to be his sole foray in the realm of advertisement. He announced a small prize in his journal *Indian Opinion* and solicited names for the movement from his readers. In response, his nephew, Maganlal Gandhi came up with sadagraha (insistence upon goodness) which was amended to the more lyrical satyagraha (insistence upon truth).

For a major part of his life, Gandhi equated truth with God. While rejecting traditional notions—God as a benevolent controller of human affairs, as the supreme creator—he wanted to give God a local habitation and a name. It is significant that he elevated truth to that status. And satyagraha became not merely a political, but also a spiritual act. He evolved from this complex idea, a system that stirred India and astonished the world.

MAHATMA GANDHI, 1926
"In English writing, we used the word satyagraha or some other equivalent English phrase for our movement."



BORN TO LEAD: Gandhi after he broke his five-day fast in Delhi, 1948

Gandhi's first satyagraha took place long before in 1893—when he was forced out of the first class carriage in South Africa because of his colour, but he neither succumbed nor reacted violently. This spontaneous civil resistance was his shortest but probably most significant satyagraha. The resistance that he started alone soon spread and he became a leader of 13,000 Indians in South Africa. An English newspaper compared the minority's first revolt—the burning of government issued identity cards, branding them as second class citizens—with the Boston Tea Party that started the American revolution.

On Gandhi's return to India in 1915, satyagraha found a greater cast of actors and a much wider theatre for putting up acts of resistance. The first satyagraha movement was in Champaran, by the indigo farmers who were forced to work in impossible conditions and the second, in Kheda in Gujarat, against unjust taxes. On March 12, 1930, Gandhiji and his 78 followers marched to the ocean of Dandi